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ENG106Z

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1/26/2026

Starting College Later in Life

There is a common belief that college is something people are supposed to do right after high school. If they do not, it can feel like they missed their chance. After interviewing Janeene Perry, I have come to see how limiting this idea is. Janeene returned to college at age 42, and her experience shows that starting later in life can lead to success rather than failure. Rather than being a setback, her age became an advantage that shaped how she approached school. Her life experience and determination helped her balance school with family and work, and earning a degree gave her confidence and long term stability. Her story challenges the assumption that education only works when it happens early in life.

Janeene's path to college was not a straight one. She explained that "the first time I went to college I was 16, but that didn't last," and that her successful return happened much later. What finally pushed her to enroll was timing. She waited until all her children were enrolled in school before making the commitment to return to college. At that point, her life looked very different from that of a traditional student. She had "a husband, children, and a business" to split her time between. Before applying, her biggest hesitation was not knowing what a school and home life balance would look like.

Even with these concerns, she felt supported. Janeene told me that everyone encouraged her decision and that her husband was her biggest supporter, which helped her feel confident enough to return.

One of the hardest parts of going back to school was balancing all her responsibilities. Janeene described the challenge as “splitting my time efficiently between education, being physically and emotionally present for my family, and helping run a business.” To manage this, she relied on discipline and structure. Janeene knew no matter how hard it would be, finding an effective way to manage her time needed to happen. She used time blocking along with only taking twelve credits a term. Her mornings began at four in the morning, when she would study and finish homework while the rest of her family still slept. By the end of the day, she was often exhausted and compared it to “running a race at 42 against a bunch of 18 year olds.” Her life as a non-traditional student was demanding both physically and mentally, but it also showed her commitment to finishing what she started.

Despite the challenges, starting college later gave Janeene a very different mindset toward learning. She explained that she never felt too old to be there and said she was excited to learn. She also said that she had a much greater appreciation for education than when she was younger. This appreciation made her more engaged in her classes and more comfortable communicating with professors. One thing that surprised Janeene about being a non-traditional student was “how easy it was to communicate with my professors.” She often talked with them before class to make sure she was prepared, which helped her feel more confident and supported as a student.

A typical school day for Janeene looked very different from that of a younger student. She drove thirty minutes each way to campus and used that time to listen to textbooks or articles through her car's bluetooth system. Between classes, she studied, went to the library, or used tutors, especially since some subjects took longer for her to retain. Lunch was usually spent in the non-traditional student lounge with a handful of other students, where they talked about work life balance or helped each other study. After coming home in the evening, Janeene cooked dinner, put her kids to bed, and then continued studying. Her schedule required constant effort, but she stayed determined. Compared to traditional students with fewer responsibilities, Janeene's routine required far more discipline and sacrifice.

The long term impact of returning to college was significant. Janeene said that university “really did boost my confidence.” She earned a Bachelor of Science in public health with a minor in human biology and was eventually hired by Yamhill County Public Health. Janeene says college changed her life for the better. SHe explained that with her degree she now earns four times the wage she previously earned and had benefits, retirement, and a pension. These were things she did not have before returning to school. This stability also means she does not have to worry as much about her future or place that burden on her children.

Janeene’s experience shows that there is no single right age for college. She believes it depends on the person and explained that she had more patience for learning as a non-traditional student. When she says “you are never too old to learn,” she means that people deserve second chances to grow, learn and build a stable future. Her story proves that starting college later in life can lead to deeper motivation and

commitment. Her experience challenges the idea that college is only for the young and shows that starting later can sometimes make success more meaningful.